BENGALI COLLECTION

NO. 09



WEST BENGAL ORIGIN

Kumro Chhokka

❀

Sweet-Savory Pumpkin Delight

A Gentle, Comforting Bengali Side Dish

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Kumro Chhokka

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Kumro Chhokka

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DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Quiet Comfort of Sweet Pumpkin

Kumro chhokka belongs to a distinctly Bengali style of vegetable cookery — the "chhokka" — a dry or lightly sauced preparation, often mildly sweetened, that sits gently alongside the more intensely flavored dishes on a Bengali thali, offering a moment of soft, comforting balance rather than competing for attention. Pumpkin (kumro), naturally sweet when cooked down, is a favorite vegetable for this treatment.

The dish's gentle sweetness, built from a touch of sugar working with the pumpkin's own natural sugars, reflects a broader tendency in Bengali cuisine to weave subtle sweetness through even savory dishes — a defining characteristic that distinguishes Bengali food from many other Indian regional cuisines, most famously visible in Bengal's celebrated sweets, but present in savory cooking too.

Kumro chhokka rarely appears on restaurant menus, remaining instead a fixture of home cooking — the kind of unassuming side dish that quietly rounds out a meal without ever demanding the spotlight, valued by Bengali families precisely for that understated, comforting simplicity.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Quiet Comfort of Sweet Pumpkin, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Part of the Bengali "chhokka" tradition — mildly sweetened, gently spiced vegetable side dishes meant to balance more intense flavors on the plate. Reflects the broader Bengali culinary tendency to weave subtle sweetness through savory cooking, a hallmark of the region's food culture. Rarely found on restaurant menus, remaining primarily a home-cooking dish valued for its understated comfort. A dish often prepared for its simplicity and ease, especially in households with younger children or older family members who prefer gentler flavors.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

10m	20m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Kadai or wide pan
- Wooden spoon

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Kumro chhokka keeps refrigerated for up to 3 days and reheats well with a small splash of water if needed. It freezes reasonably well for up to a month, given its relatively simple ingredient profile.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the dish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Pumpkin (kumro), peeled and cubed	1 lb	450 g	1 lb
Mustard oil	2 tbsp	30 ml	2 chammach
Panch phoron	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Bay leaf	1	1	1
Dried red chili	1	1	1
Ginger paste	1 tsp	5 g	1 chammach
Turmeric powder	¼ tsp	1 g	¼ chammach
Cumin powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Sugar	1½ tsp	6 g	1½ chammach
Salt	¾ tsp	4.5 g	to taste
Water	¼ cup	60 ml	¼ katori
Ghee, to finish — optional	1 tsp	5 g	1 chammach

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Any orange winter squash, such as butternut squash or kabocha, is a good substitute if Indian pumpkin (kumro) isn't available — the flavor and texture translate well. This is one of the simplest and most accessible dishes in the collection, using pantry-friendly spices and a widely available vegetable, making it an easy entry point for cooks new to Bengali cuisine.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Preparing the Pumpkin

01 CUT THE PUMPKIN

Peel and cut the pumpkin into roughly ¾-inch / 2 cm cubes — a fairly small, uniform size helps it cook down evenly into the soft, slightly mashed texture this dish is known for.

02 PREPARE THE TEMPERING INGREDIENTS

Have the panch phoron, bay leaf, and dried red chili measured and ready, since the tempering step moves quickly once the oil is hot.



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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Preparing the Pumpkin, continued

COOKING CHECKPOINT

Uniformly cut pumpkin pieces will cook at the same rate, which is important for this dish's characteristic soft, slightly broken-down texture.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Cooking the Chhokka

03 TEMPER THE PANCH PHORON

Heat mustard oil in a kadai and temper the panch phoron, bay leaf, and dried red chili until fragrant, about 30 seconds.

04 ADD THE PUMPKIN

Add the cubed pumpkin along with the ginger paste, turmeric, and cumin powder, stirring to coat evenly.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Cooking the Chhokka, continued

05 COOK COVERED UNTIL SOFT

Add the water, cover, and cook on medium-low heat for 12–15 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the pumpkin is very soft and beginning to break down slightly at the edges.

06 FINISH WITH SUGAR AND SALT

Stir in the sugar and salt, mashing a few pieces lightly with the back of your spoon to help create the dish's characteristic soft, slightly chunky texture. Cook uncovered for a final 3–4 minutes to let any excess liquid reduce.

Texture indicator. kumro chhokka should be soft enough that some pieces naturally break down, creating a semi-mashed consistency rather than staying in firm, distinct cubes.

07 FINISH WITH GHEE

Stir in a small spoonful of ghee just before serving, if using, for extra richness and aroma.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Cooking the pumpkin uncovered from the start dries it out before it has a chance to soften properly. Keep it covered for most of the cooking time, uncovering only at the end to reduce excess liquid.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served as a gentle side dish alongside rice, dal, and a more robustly spiced main dish.
- A common choice for young children or elderly family members who prefer milder flavors.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a small bowl as part of a Bengali thali, offering a moment of soft sweetness among the other dishes.

Family Style

- A comforting, easy side dish that rounds out a home-cooked meal without much fuss.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Texture Right

- Cooking covered for most of the process is what allows the pumpkin to soften fully without drying out.
- Lightly mashing a few pieces at the end, rather than leaving everything in firm cubes, gives the dish its traditional, comforting consistency.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- This dish reheats easily, making it a practical make-ahead side for busy weeknights.
- Pumpkin can be pre-cut and refrigerated a day ahead to save time when you're ready to cook.

RESTAURANT TRICK

A small pinch of roasted cumin powder sprinkled on top just before serving adds a final layer of aroma that many home cooks skip but that makes a noticeable difference.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

95 kcal	1.5 g	14 g	4 g	3 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Kumro Chhokka with Chana Dal — some households add a handful of cooked chana dal for extra substance.

Kumro Bhaja — a simpler, drier fried version without the sweet-savory sauce, another common preparation.

Kumro Chhokka with Coconut — a version finished with grated coconut for extra texture and richness.

Can I use a different type of squash?

Yes — butternut squash or kabocha squash both work well if Indian pumpkin isn't available, with very similar results.

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Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Why is my dish too watery?

Uncover and cook a little longer at the end to let excess liquid reduce — pumpkin releases moisture as it softens.

Is this dish very sweet?

No — it has a subtle, gentle sweetness rather than being distinctly sweet like a dessert. The sugar is meant to enhance, not dominate, the flavor.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Kumro	Bengali for pumpkin, the primary vegetable in this dish.
Chhokka	a Bengali cooking style referring to a dry or lightly sauced, often mildly sweetened vegetable preparation.
Panch Phoron	a Bengali five-spice blend used to temper this dish.
Sorshe Tel	Bengali for mustard oil, used for its distinctive pungent flavor.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Kumro Chhokka

10m	20m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	**Easy**
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

DISH

Pumpkin	450 g
Mustard oil	30 ml
Panch phoron	1.5 g
Bay leaf	1
Dried red chili	1
Ginger paste	5 g
Turmeric powder	1 g
Cumin powder	1.5 g
Sugar	6 g
Salt	4.5 g
Water	60 ml
Ghee	5 g

METHOD

01 **Cut the pumpkin.** Peel and cut the pumpkin into roughly ¾-inch / 2 cm cubes — a fairly small, uniform size helps it cook down evenly into the soft, slightly mashed texture this dish is known for.

02 **Prepare the tempering ingredients.** Have the panch phoron, bay leaf, and dried red chili measured and ready, since the tempering step moves quickly once the oil is hot.

03 **Temper the panch phoron.** Heat mustard oil in a kadai and temper the panch phoron, bay leaf, and dried red chili until fragrant, about 30 seconds.

04 **Add the pumpkin.** Add the cubed pumpkin along with the ginger paste, turmeric, and cumin powder, stirring to coat evenly.

05 **Cook covered until soft.** Add the water, cover, and cook on medium-low heat for 12–15 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the pumpkin is very soft and beginning to break down slightly at the edges.

06 **Finish with sugar and salt.** Stir in the sugar and salt, mashing a few pieces lightly with the back of your spoon to help create the dish's characteristic soft, slightly chunky texture.

07 **Finish with ghee.** Stir in a small spoonful of ghee just before serving, if using, for extra richness and aroma.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Pumpkin	450 g	☐ Mustard oil	30 ml
☐ Panch phoron	1.5 g	☐ Bay leaf	1
☐ Dried red chili	1	☐ Ginger paste	5 g
☐ Turmeric powder	1 g	☐ Cumin powder	1.5 g
☐ Sugar	6 g	☐ Salt	4.5 g
☐ Ghee	5 g		

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